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God as Fetish and the Eternal Delight of Jouissance

In the section *The Voice of the Devil*, within *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, William Blake outlines a reciprocal relationship that occurs between the body and soul, a circular relationship between the energy of life and the force of reason. To begin to describe this dichotomy, he ventriloquizes the Devil to make the claim that “All Bibles or sacred codes” are guilty of three specific errors:

1. That Man has two real existing principles: Viz: a Body & a Soul.
2. That Energy, call'd Evil, is alone from the Body; & that Reason, call'd Good, is alone from the Soul.
3. That God will torment Man in Eternity for following his Energies. (Blake, 250).

According to Blake's Devil, all religious structures believe in a binary split between the body and the soul. The body, and its energy is an evil to be resisted through the righteous force of reason. “Good is the passive that obeys Reason. Evil is the active springing from Energy,” and to obey reason, or good “is Heaven,” whilst an evil, active body “is Hell,” (250). The core of religious institution, to Blake's Devil, is founded on the suppression of energy, of the reasoned control of self, or in other words, the mediation of desire.

These systems of control apparently argued by religious institutions, the enforced mediation of the body's energy through reason, is strikingly similar to Marcuse's reading of Freud, where a person's culture “constrains not only his societal but also his biological

existence,” (1). The pleasure principle, or Eros, is the “destructive force of instinctual gratification,” a seemingly infinite bodily desire that encounters reality and recoils due to its inability to fully gratify itself (Marcuse, 2). Following this reaction, “a new principle of mental functioning gains ascendancy,” the reality principle, which mediates the body’s drive for immediate gratification (Marcuse, 1). According to Marcuse, this reality principle, the psyche’s response to the energy springing from the body meeting the natural world, is what develops the capacity for reason in the first place:

Under the reality principle the human being develops the function of reason: it learns to “test” the reality, to distinguish between good and bad, true and false, useful and harmful (2).

With this in mind, the proclaimed erroneous reasoning of organized religion is the differentiation of good and evil, where reason, which produces these categories in the first place, posits itself as righteous. Control and reason, or the reality principle, is thought of as the soul of humanity, while the pleasure principle is a destructive, bodily urge that should be suppressed, lest God punish man eternally.

How biblical texts enforce the good of reason then makes sense, as the “reality principle materializes in a system of institutions,” like the church, which guides their followers to learn “the requirements of the reality principle as law and order,” (Marcuse, 2). The Devil argues that all existing sacred codes are guilty of this structuring: the prioritization of reason over energy. The religious institutions in power facilitate the limits of the reality principle and therefore the limits of the soul.

But Blake's Devil provides an alternative vision to this supposed error of religion. He reverses this differentiation between soul and body, between reality and pleasure, or Heaven and Hell. Humans have "no Body distinct from [their] Soul" as the body is "a portion of Soul discern'd by the five Senses, the chief inlets of Soul in this age," (Blake, 250). The capacity to sense the world, and to define it with the reasoning soul, requires the body's energy to generate the five senses, and to motivate reason. The body allows the soul to exist in the first place, like how the pleasure principle motivates the reality principle, which is taken up as a means to acquire a "delayed, restrained, but 'assured' pleasure," (Marcuse. 2). The body's drive for pleasure is still essential to the equation of life, as "Energy is the only life, and is from the Body," and through reason, which "is the bound or outwards circumference of Energy," the motivating force of desire is bound into a containable form (250-251). Rather than demonizing the body's energy, the Devil proposes a balanced relationship between the two (251). The body generates the ability to reason, and reason attempts to provide the body a means to actualize this urge which strives for an ever far away "Eternal Delight" (251).

With institutions subsisting on the notion that energy should be suppressed, the Devil likely considers these to be structures impeding the ability to access this eternal pleasure. In *A Memorable Fancy* which immediately follows *The Voice of the Devil*, the narrative perspective seemingly switches back to Blake himself, who describes an encounter with "a mighty Devil" that he makes out through "the abyss" of his "five senses," (252). This Devil, "folded in black clouds," writes the following sentence on an unnamed object with his "corroding fires":

How do you know but ev'ry Bird that cuts the airy way,
Is an immense world of delight, clos'd by your senses five?
(252).

The inlets of the soul, the body's senses which are determined by the outward circumference of reason, are thought to be but shackles by this Devil. The institution of the church, which determines reason, our ability to make sense of our senses, is what the Devil believes closes off this world of immense delight to the body and soul. Eternal Delight, and the instant, continual gratification that's sought out by the pleasure principle, is mediated by reason, or the reality imposed on our senses. The mediating force of reason, and its defining institution, is something this Devil would seemingly like to do away with.

But reason isn't something that can be broken through easily, as it's constituted and limited by language itself. Language is the reason that binds energy to reality. Only the ideas associated with "language appear to us to conform to reality, and we disregard whatever others might be imagined," (Saussure, 67). Speakers of a given language only have access to whatever available signs constitute that language, and language itself "is a genuine institution" that's passed from generation to generation, in much the same way that reason is institutionalized (Saussure, 76). The pleasure principle is then mediated by, not only religious institutions, but the reality of language in a given social reality. The circumference of the soul is defined by our ability to conceptualize fragments of Blake's Eternal Delight through the words passed down to us by social structures. And within the sacred code of the Bible, the word "God" might work as an attempt to contain and externalize this active, infinite desire the Devil taunts Blake with.

In Psalm 42 and 43, *Desire for God and His Temple*, an exiled, homesick psalmist reaches out to this God through lyric, in an attempt to have his soul's thirst for "the living God" quenched (Line 3). Psalm 42 opens with, "As the hind longs for the / running waters, / so my soul longs for you, / O God." (Line 2). Immediately, the psalmist's desire for God is conflated with that of an animal and instinctual desire. The body's energy, or the pleasure principle, rises

out and reaches the limits of the soul, yet it thirsts for the rest, and God defines this lack that the body craves. In fact, the psalmist seems powerless in the face of his own lack, his soul faced with its mortal limits. Line 5 seems to define these limits fairly explicitly, as the psalmist states, “Those times I recall, / now that I pour out my soul / within me,” presenting a metaphor that transforms the soul into a fluid, and therefore energetic object, incapable of moving beyond its own defining reason. The spilling of his soul within himself functions as an act of remembrance, imagining or fantasy. Language and reason constructs the means for the psalmist to recall and internally represent “the house of God, / Amid loud cries of joy and thanksgiving,” but these images only continue to represent what he lacks: the celebration of God, the image of his own unfulfilled desire. The limits of language, of reason, leave the psalmist thirsty, ungratified, and adrift.

Only shortly after, he questions his soul’s response to this internal remembrance in a line repeated thrice over the course of these two psalms, “Why are you so downcast, / O my soul? / Why do you sigh within me?”. His soul, now autonomous and separate from him, feels the weight of this lack. Its own internal limits seemingly reverberate with a built up energy pushing up against the walls of language. Though, his solution is to yet again use language as an internal act of remembrance, to try to use reason to bring God inside him, “Within me my soul is / downcast; / so will I remember you” (Line 7). In this final line, God’s image quickly caves under the weight of this ever growing desire, with his name simply replaced by an abstract “you”, a direct othering. The metaphoric waters of God, this other, that the psalmist was previously thirsting for, seemingly burst from the failed container of the other’s presence: “Deep calls unto deep / and in the roar of your / cataracts; / All your breakers and your / billows / pass over me,” (Line 8). The container for desire, reason, reasons with its own lack of capacity to fulfill this

need; God cannot be remembered because God is beyond reason. God is that which the psalmist lacks. The vast negative space of energy, the remainder of pleasure to be had within Eternal Delight limited by reason, is attempted to be defined by reason. Inevitably, the image collapses. As deep calls unto deep, the doubly negated image of God, the presence of an absent object of desire, shatters under the impossibility of being contained.

To Blake's Devil, this conclusion feels inevitable; our senses and language itself are a representational abyss, attempting to reason the unreasonable. Objects and words make the real, as to name is to bring into being, but to name something beyond naming creates an unstable and brittle object. God, in this case, becomes the definition of desired infinitude, and therefore the means by which that othered desire can be accessed. The sacred code of the Bible, defined in his name, acts as a voice of reason, determining moral behavior and rationality, as the reality principle does for the sake of later gratification. But this voice comes from an external object that rejects the energy and desire of the subject desiring it. A believer in this code, with the faith that these energies must be bound by the reason of the inaccessible God, turns themselves into God's object through their desire.

This is similar to Lacan's understanding of neurotic fetishization, where the subject objectifies themselves by confusing the "Other's lack with the Other's demand," (*Ecrits* 698). The Other, the speculated infinitude of pleasure mediated by reality, inherently lacks the subject viewing it. In order to preserve this infinite and all-consuming image, the subject allows the demands of the Other to overtake and contain its desire for it: "Consequently, the Other's demand takes on the function of the object in the neurotic's fantasy," (Lacan, *Ecrits* 698). God's specular image, Man, takes on his reasoning and laws to avoid eternal punishment, to attain Eternal Delight. "In fact, the image of the ideal Father is a neurotic's fantasy," and this idealized

Father, the specular image of Man, is believed to be capable of “the true function of the Father, which is fundamentally to unite (and not to oppose) a desire to the Law,” (Lacan, *Ecrits* 698). The image of the Father is created with the belief that reason can unify and gratify the energy inside of a given subject via repression. But, as the Devil makes clear, this system, this fetishization, limits the subject to the abyss of their senses. Bodily energy will continue to push against the walls of soulful reason, and desire, which forms out of this restraint “is a defense, a defense against going beyond a limit in jouissance,” (Lacan, *Ecrits* 699).

Blake seemingly believes there’s a way to break through the restraints of the senses, the limits of reason, to reach that Eternal Delight that exists in an all-encompassing energy. There is a way to attain this sort of jouissance that “overruns” the senses (Lacan, *Seminar* 46). And since what the “pleasure principle maintains is a limit in respect to jouissance,” the solution might be to somehow expand a subject’s capacity for sensation (Lacan, *Seminar* 46). Blake later describes ancient poets as those who “animated all sensible objects with Gods or Geniuses, calling them by the names” of “whatever their enlarged & numerous senses could perceive” (255). The desire for jouissance, the Eternal Delight that exists past knowledgeable pleasure, is dispersed about anything remotely sensible. Poets, according to Blake, are capable of this feat given they have an enlarged sense of reality; they have numerous senses, potentially from a more free language to sense reality with, and therefore an expanded perception of soul and expanded volume of energy.

In a later *Memorable Fancy*, the prophet Isaiah then confirms this, “I saw no God, nor heard any, in a finite organical perception; but my senses discover’d the infinite in everything,” and that he was “perswaded, & remain confirm’d, that the voice of honest indignation is the voice of God” (256). His ability to expand sense allows it to break from the limited organic medium; by seeing and hearing no God, he found God everywhere there was unfairness, which seems to

be any restriction of the truth of energy: its infinite presence in everything. Afterall, jouissance “has to be refused in order to be obtained,” and by refusing the image of God as capable of fulfilling the subject’s desire, the subject finds God in all things (Lacan, *Ecrits* 700). The poet-prophet is capable of subverting God through language; they can express a voice of honest indignation against the system that “enslav’d the vulgar by attempting to realize or abstract the mental deities from their objects,” (Blake, 255). Every sensible object should be its own God, and its own end. To express energy’s frustrations with the limits of sense allows for language to push beyond a currently perceivable reality through negation. The totalizing image of God, of knowledgeable sense-pleasure, is formed only to be broken again. To sense differently is to create new meaning, and this self-generation is where meaning and energy is to be found, through a drive towards iteration.

In fact, what “necessitates repetition is jouissance,” since the honest indignation that comes from experiencing only partial actualization forms this “search for jouissance as repetition” (Lacan, *Seminar* 45). This negation of the subject’s limited sensed state, or the boundaries of their soul, “which is properly speaking what goes against life,” is undertaken in order to iteratively define a new one, and constantly attempt to push the boundaries of sense outwards (Lacan, *Seminar* 45). Blake even claims that “the whole of creation will be consumed and appear infinite and holy,” and that this will “come to pass by an improvement of sensual enjoyment,” (257). The poet-prophet can then expand sensual pleasure and language through iteration, working towards the consumption of the whole of creation. But these iterations are notably always limited in form, incapable of achieving pure actualization, as they’re still bound by some form of reason or language. Repetition is in fact always the “return of jouissance,” because in every “repetition, something is produced that is a defect, a failure,” (Lacan, *Seminar*

46). Jouissance calls itself into being recursively through its indignant response to the imperfection inherent in any single state. It generates constant change and the movement of energy. Eternal Delight is this constant change, an infinitely mobile energy, and Blake seemingly strives for this recursive quality in his own work.

The *Marriage of Heaven and Hell* starts off with a six-stanza, twenty-two-lined poem titled *The Argument*. The poem begins and ends with the same stanza of two lines, “Rintrah roars & shakes his fires in the burden’d air; / Hungry clouds swag on the deep” (249). Rintrah, the name given to a god in Blake's mythology, becomes both the start and end points of this argument, which already creates a recursive structure. This repeated stanza provides an image of the imaginary god’s wrath; his anger is represented through an animalistic roar, and chaotic dispersion of fire into “burden’d air”. This burden implies a weightier atmosphere, an increased mass dragging the air down to the earth, pressurizing and restricting it. Rintrah’s wrath, his fire, attempts to oppose this burden, to burn through the restrictive atmosphere. In this way, this initial dichotomy mirrors the pleasure principle’s reaction to reality, and the reaction and repetition driven by jouissance. Rintrah attempts to burn through the limits of reality, of reason, which is fitting given the Devil himself taunted Blake’s limitations with writings in a corrosive fire. Language becomes the means for deconstruction, the voice of honest indignation, in this dichotomy between obedience and rebellion.

The “hungry clouds” that follow Rintrah’s expressed wrath, immediately return to this idea of “burden’d air,” as clouds are formed from water condensation in the air. And these clouds are anthropomorphized the moment they’re introduced through the adjective “hungry.” It indicates a lack, and therefore a desire sought out by them. Given the fact that clouds grow through the accumulation of water vapor, of weighted air, it seems to produce the idea that as

Rintrah disperses the weight, it's sought after by these clouds, only to recreate the initial conditions. Rintrah's wrath opposes the accumulation, yet desire, as a barrier to the limits of *jouissance*, continually strives to perpetuate weight and restriction. The previously established dichotomy is then elaborated on, in which obedience and rebellion, condensation and dispersion, the air and Rintrah, are inherently reliant on one another for their current action; they're locked in a cyclical stalemate, with Rintrah situated "in" the air, and the clouds "on the deep," giving them a sense of exteriority to this arena of opposition. The energetic drive for *jouissance* is always confined by reason, trapped in an unending battle that only recreates its own faulty conditions. Rintrah ends the poem, and Rintrah starts the poem, always burdened and always fighting.

But, this constant repetition and cyclicity is a constant movement of energy. It's bound by desire, only to break through this reasoned defense and confine itself again. Language pushes outwards, binds the ever mobile desire, and moves from state to state for as long as it can be uttered. *Eternal Delight*, which is the infinite expansion of energy, seemingly describes this recursive pattern of *jouissance*. Rather than creating a fixed container for desire, a singular God of some kind, capable of binding reason and the senses and therefore energy, gratification can be actualized by considering change and indeterminacy as this constant object. The five inlets of the soul have no reason to be limited to only five if the corrosive fires of language are capable of deconstructing these limitations. Marrying oppositions like Heaven and Hell, or the body and the soul, by revealing their eternal, recursive reliance on one another allows Blake to present the argument that *Eternal Delight* and punishment are actually one and the same thing. Like the idea of *jouissance* producing a sensation that goes beyond pleasure, beyond pain, *Eternal Delight* is the recognition of the paradoxes inherent in binary oppositions. The soul and the body are joined

together, and as the body motivates the soul for the sake of delight, it constantly rebels against the limitations of reason.

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